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Communication and Persuasion

Central and Peripheral Routes to Attitude Change

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To Lynn and Barbara

Preface

It has been over 10 years since we initiated work on our first series of collaborative experiments. As graduate students, we had great fun planning, conducting, and writing this research (Petty & Cacioppo, 1977). We enjoyed arguing with each other at our initial meeting in 1973 and have subsequently become best friends, but neither of us suspected at the time that we would or could actively maintain a research collaboration over the next decade, or that we would now find ourselves in a position to write this monograph.

As we note in Chapter 1, we began our studies of persuasion at a time when social psychology was in "crisis," and interest in research on attitude change in particular was declining. As we write this, we are aware of six new volumes on persuasion that are in press or in preparation and that should appear over the next few years. In retrospect, it is not so surprising that research on attitudes and persuasion would reemerge as a central concern of social psychology. We believe that human feelings, beliefs, and behaviors, whether in the domain of interpersonal relations (e.g., marriage, aggression), politics (e.g., voting, revolution), health (e.g., following a medical regimen), or economics (e.g., consumer purchases) are greatly influenced by the evaluations people have of other people, objects, and issues. Furthermore, evaluations (attitudes) are influenced by affect, cognition, and behavior. Because of this reciprocal interdependence and the general importance of the attitude construct for many disciplines, attitude theory, perhaps more than any other field of inquiry in social psychology, has the potential to provide one of the general theories for the social sciences.

In this monograph we present a general framework for understanding the attitude changes that result from exposure to persuasive communications. This theory, which we have called the Elaboration Likelihood Model (ELM), outlines two "routes to persuasion." One route is based on a careful and thoughtful assessment of the central merits of the position advocated (central route). The other is based on some cognitive, affective, or behavioral

cue in the persuasion context which becomes attached to the advocacy or allows a relatively simple inference as to the merits of the position advocated (peripheral route). Similar amounts of attitude change can be produced via either route. However, the changes induced via the central route require more cogitation and are postulated to be more persistent, resistant to counterpersuasion, and predictive of behavior. We believe that these two routes to persuasion are applicable to the full range of situations in which people are influenced by persuasive communications. For example, we believe the model holds promise for explaining a variety of effects of interest to social scientists ranging from (a) the conditions under which people will vote for candidates based on relatively simple cues such as political party or physical attractiveness rather than their issue positions, to (b) the situations in which attitude changes induced by advertisements will and will not lead to changes in purchase intentions, to (c) the extent to which belief changes induced by a therapist will prove resistant to countervailing forces. Despite our optimistic view regarding the potential applicability of the model, our focus here is on the initial basic research designed to test and validate the framework. We hope that the body of this book will be of some general interest to all scholars and students of the psychology of persuasion. As such, the material should be appropriate for segments of courses on attitude change and may provide useful supplementary material for graduate courses on topics for which the psychology of influence is a central focus (such as influence processes in counseling, psychology of advertising and consumer behavior, etc.).

Although the major purpose of this monograph is to present the ELM and our own program of research on persuasion which examines various features of the model, we also present the work of others when it provides evidence that is directly relevant to our conceptualization of persuasion. It is important to note that there are many studies that can be viewed as consistent (or inconsistent) with the ELM that we have chosen *not* to cover here. One difficulty in analyzing previous work is that most persuasion studies have not paid much attention to the content of the persuasive messages employed in the research or to background variables (such as prior knowledge) that might determine the extent and/or direction of message elaboration. This poses a great difficulty for reinterpretation because, as we explain in the text, the ELM may make *opposite* predictions for the effect of some variable on persuasion depending upon whether the message employed in the experiment was generally strong and likely to elicit favorable cognitions, or generally weak and likely to elicit unfavorable thoughts. Furthermore, the ELM may make different predictions for one variable depending upon the level of another factor that was not manipulated in the study (e.g., is the message topic one of high, low, or uncertain personal relevance). Because of these complexities, we have focused our attention on those studies conducted by others that have the necessary features (e.g., a manipulation of argument quality, a manipulation of personal relevance) that permit relatively unambiguous interpretation. One

desirable feature of the ELM, we think, is that it may encourage future persuasion researchers to consider message quality and important background variables (such as personal relevance) in order to more definitively pin down the processes mediating the impact of the variables under study.

Acknowledgments

It is difficult to write a book like this without the support and assistance of many people. First and foremost, we owe a continuing debt to our wives, Lynn and Barbara, who have put up with us and our work habits for many years. We love them dearly and would be lost without them. Our families are also a source of persistent encouragement, and we are very grateful for this.

We have been fortunate over the years to have worked with many talented social psychologists including Tim Brock, Robert Cialdini, Tony Greenwald, John Harvey, Steve Harkins, Bibb Latané, Tom Ostrom, Kip Williams, and Gary Wells. Our contact with them has enhanced the quality of this volume (though they should not be blamed for any flaws found!). It is important to note that many of the studies reported in this book would not have been conducted were it not for the efforts of a group of dedicated and ambitious graduate students and postdoctoral and Fulbright fellows. These people—Cheri Christensen, Rachel Goldman, Curt Haugtvedt, Martin Heesacker, Chuan Feng Kao, Jeff Kasmer, Hai Sook Kim, Mary Losch, Beverly Marshall-Goodell, Kathy Morris, Rik Pieters, Jim Puckett, Leo Quintanar, Greg Rennier, David Schumann, Joe Sidera, Cal Stoltenberg, and Lou Tassinary—were and are a pleasure to work with and make academic life fulfilling. We are also indebted to the thousands of undergraduates who provided the data for the studies that we report here and the many students with whom we have worked as experimenters and research assistants. Their talents were very valuable, and we are pleased that many have gone on to distinguished careers ranging from law (Charlotte Lowell) to acting (Kate Capshaw). Some have even decided to become social psychologists (Tom Geen, Alan Strathman)!

Finally, we owe a debt of gratitute to those colleagues who commented on various portions of the manuscript (Icek Ajzen, Bob Cialdini, Marty Heesacker, Chet Insko, Wolfgang Stroebe, and Abe Tesser), to the National Science Foundation for providing support for our research program over the past decade, and to the professionals at Springer-Verlag who were a joy to work with over the long course of preparing this volume.

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